

The PAYBACK Framework

Score your first AI agent project before you build it

Elliot Betancourt



Every list of AI agent ideas looks equally promising until you've built the wrong one first. Score each candidate across these five dimensions — the highest total wins the build slot.

1 Loop Frequency

5 = daily or more 3 = weekly 1 = monthly or ad-hoc

How often does this workflow run? Rare workflows give you fewer chances to learn.

2 Approval Depth

5 = zero — ships directly 3 = one review step 1 = multiple sign-offs

How many approval steps sit between the output and a real outcome?

3 Error Cost

5 = cheap, caught immediately 3 = moderate, caught in a day 1 = expensive, surfaces downstream

How expensive is a wrong answer to catch?

4 Verification Speed

5 = immediate signal 3 = hours 1 = weeks, or unclear

How fast do you know whether it actually worked?

5 Data Access

5 = structured and available 3 = needs some wiring 1 = requires new integration

Does the agent already have what it needs to do the job?

Decision Matrix

Total Score	Recommendation
21-25	Build this first.
15-20	Good second project.
10-14	Wait — restructure first.
Below 10	Keep a human on it.

The bottleneck isn't the model. It's picking the loop that closes fast enough to teach you something.